

Seagrass beds

Nearly all the plantlike organisms that live in oceans are various forms of algae such as seaweeds, which are not true plants. The only true plants that have become adapted to life in seawater are the seagrasses that grow in sandy or muddy shallows. Seagrass beds provide sheltered habitats for small fish, and vital food for sea cows and green sea turtles.

BEAKY GRAZER

In tropical coral seas, seagrasses grow in the sand of sheltered coral lagoons. They are eaten by the green sea turtle—the only species of sea turtle that is herbivorous. Seagrass is so important to this animal that some varieties are known as turtle grass. Like other turtles, the green sea turtle has no teeth, and crops the soft seagrass with its sharp-edged beak.

UNDERWATER MEADOWS

Unlike seaweeds, seagrasses are true plants with proper roots and stems with internal veins. They also have flowers that open underwater. Their long grassy leaves absorb sunlight and use its energy to make food, so they only grow in shallow, relatively clear water, where they form broad underwater meadows.



Sea turtles produce salty tears to get rid of the excess salt from their bodies.

